

Federal Appropriations to Municipal Police Departments

The Case for Smart Money: Investing in People Over Post-Incident Equipment

This report examines recent federal budget allocations and earmarks directed to municipal and local law enforcement, identifies patterns in how those dollars are used, and proposes a targeted continuing-education grant focused on cultural competency and de-escalation. The guiding principle is simple: **smart money invests in people, not in fancy cleanup equipment after the fact.**

1. Scale of Federal Support for Local Policing

Federal funding remains a relatively modest share of overall local police budgets—generally estimated at 3–9% nationally, or roughly \$10–30 per capita against the approximately \$350 per capita that typical U.S. municipalities spend on policing. Most local law enforcement budgets are funded by local taxes and state sources. Federal dollars arrive primarily through Department of Justice (DOJ) grant programs and congressional earmarks (also called Community Project Funding).

Two programs dominate the regular grant landscape:

- **Edward Byrne Memorial Justice Assistance Grant (Byrne JAG)** — the leading formula grant for state and local criminal justice. Funds support personnel, equipment, training, technology, and a range of justice-system activities.
- **Community Oriented Policing Services (COPS)** — focused on hiring officers for community-policing strategies, plus specialized training, technology, and school-safety initiatives.

Recent Appropriation Levels (Selected)

Program / Fiscal Year	FY2023	FY2024	FY2025	FY2026
Byrne JAG (top-line)	~\$771M	~\$924M	~\$499M*	~\$964M
COPS (total account)	~\$683M	~\$685M	~\$437M*	~\$654–820M
COPS Hiring (approx.)	~\$225M	~\$157M	~\$157–257M	~\$158–256M

*FY2025 figures reflect continuing-resolution effects; community-project/earmark funding was zeroed out for that year.

After set-asides and carve-outs, the pure formula portion of Byrne JAG available to states and localities has typically ranged between roughly \$330–412 million in recent years. COPS hiring awards cover up to 75% of entry-level salary and benefits for three years (with a local match and retention requirement).

2. What the Money Is Earmarked For

Federal grants are not unrestricted operating support. They carry purpose limitations and non-supplanting rules (federal dollars must add to, not replace, what the locality would otherwise spend).

Byrne JAG allowable uses include law-enforcement programs (personnel, overtime, equipment, technology, training), prosecution and courts, prevention and education, corrections and reentry, drug treatment and enforcement, planning and technology improvement, crime-victim programs (non-compensation), and mental-health / crisis-intervention programs related to criminal justice.

Explicit prohibitions generally cover luxury items, real estate, most construction (except correctional facilities), and certain vehicles, vessels, or aircraft outside standard police use—absent extraordinary circumstances certified by the Attorney General.

Congressional earmarks (Community Project Funding) are even more specific. In FY2026, DOJ earmarks reached a record approximately \$938 million. Roughly 70% (~\$659 million) went to law-enforcement or prosecution functions, with

local governments receiving the large majority. Common funded items include radios, patrol cars, mobile command centers, surveillance and security technology, and emergency communications systems.

3. Existing Training-Related Funding

Federal support for training already exists but is modest relative to equipment and hiring streams, and it is rarely structured as broad, recurring continuing education for the full municipal workforce.

- **COPS Safer Outcomes** — funds de-escalation and crisis-response training (alternatives to force, mental/behavioral health crises, disabilities, crisis-intervention teams, community referrals). Recent annual funding has been in the \$8–15 million range, with per-agency caps based on size.
- **BJA De-escalation and Crisis Response Training** — competitive grants (up to ~\$700,000) for programs improving responses to people in crisis.
- Byrne JAG itself can and does support training, including scenario-based and de-escalation equipment, but it is not dedicated solely to cultural-competency or standardized continuing-education hours.

4. The Smart-Money Proposal

We propose a dedicated federal continuing-education grant that subsidizes 40 to 80 hours of ongoing professional development for sworn municipal officers. Priority focus areas: cultural competency, de-escalation tactics, and communication skills required by the realities of diverse communities.

Eligible uses would include tuition or registration, curriculum development or purchase, instructor costs, scenario-based or virtual-reality tools, backfill or overtime so officers can attend, and evaluation of training impact.

Priority should be given to municipal departments, with set-asides or preference for smaller agencies that face the tightest training budgets. Delivery can occur through accredited academies, community colleges, universities, or certified providers, including regional and online options to control cost.

Accountability mechanisms should require reporting of completion rates and, where feasible, outcome indicators such as use-of-force incidents, civilian complaints, or community-trust measures.

The grant can be structured as a new dedicated line under the COPS Office or as a set-aside within Byrne JAG / State and Local Law Enforcement Assistance. Either vehicle keeps the funding inside existing administrative channels while creating a clear, recurring investment in human capital.

5. Why This Is Smart Money

Equipment and technology help manage consequences. Training changes the likelihood that those consequences arise. In a society experiencing a measurable decline in interpersonal communication capacity, mutual understanding, and conflict-resolution skill, leaving the human side of policing under-supported is not neutral policy. It is a choice that makes every encounter riskier for officers and the public.

Federal appropriations already move significant sums to local departments. Redirecting a portion—or adding a modest dedicated stream—toward sustained continuing education in cultural competency and de-escalation is both a public-safety measure and a fiscal one. Better-prepared officers reduce costly incidents, litigation, and eroded trust. That is the definition of smart money: investing upstream in people rather than downstream in cleanup equipment after the fact.